SECTION 3

Who Names the Act and Who Owns the Story?

Two cases · two records each

When land changes hands, the conflict begins long before the first surveyor's peg or industrial excavator strikes the earth; it begins with language. Those in power wield bureaucratic terminology to sanitize dispossession. Communal heritage is branded "surplus," ancestral forests are classified as "mine blocks," and systemic exploitation is reframed under the banner of "development," "national progress," or "corporate stewardship."

This section sets state and corporate archives directly against the counter-archives preserved by indigenous communities. Comparing the 1887 Dawes Act in the United States with ongoing coal extraction in India's Hasdeo Arand forest reveals identical institutional playbooks separated by over a century. Official records: statutes, clearance certificates, and glossy sustainability brochures, depict an orderly, legal redistribution of resources. In contrast, tribal petitions, forged consent controversies, and grassroots resistance tell a story of existential survival and broken treaties. By laying official claims alongside community realities, this exhibit asks: Who gets to decide what is legal, what is theft, and whose memory becomes history?

Audio guide · Section 3
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